



GUINEA

Capital city: Conakry
Area: 94,926 sq miles (245,860 sq km)
Population: 8,500,000
Official language: French
Major religions: Muslim 65%, traditional beliefs 4%, Christian 1%
Government: Multi-party democracy
Currency: Guinea franc
Adult literacy rate: 27%
Life expectancy: 46 years
People per doctor: 10,000
Televisions: 7 per 1,000 people

GUINEA BISSAU

Capital city: Bissau
Area: 13,946 sq miles (36,120 sq km)
Population: 1,500,000
Official language: Portuguese
Major religions: Traditional beliefs 54%, Muslim 38%, Christian 8%
Government: Multi-party democracy
Currency: CFA franc
Adult literacy rate: 40%
Life expectancy: 43 years
People per doctor: 5,000
Televisions: no figures available

GUINEA

ONCE A FRENCH COLONY, this fertile, hilly country is rich in minerals and has perfect weather conditions for growing many crops, including bananas, citrus fruits, and rice. These factors could make Guinea a rich country, but it is one of the poorest in the world, with a life expectancy of just 46 years and only very basic medical and educational facilities. This is largely the result of the French leaving Guinea without financial support, poor management of the economy, and years of harsh political rule under Sekou Touré, who was president from 1958–84.

About two-thirds of Guinea's population lives in small villages like this one.



PEOPLE OF GUINEA

A varied mix of peoples, including the Malinke, Fulani, and Soussou, live in Guinea. Most of them are Muslim. The Malinke make up about a third of the population and are named after a mountainous area on the Mali border. This was once part of the great Mali Empire, which dominated West Africa in medieval times. Today, the Malinke are famous for their centuries-old storytelling and musical skills.



THE GUINEA HIGHLANDS

Thick forest covers the mountainous Guinea Highlands in the south of the country. In addition to providing lumber products, conditions in this highly fertile area are ideal for growing various crops, including coffee. Three of the region's major rivers – the Niger, the Gambia, and the Senegal – have their sources here. Rich iron deposits exist here, and the whole area is nourished by abundant rainfall.



MINING

The mountainous areas of Guinea are rich in a mineral ore called bauxite. Ores are substances from which metals can be obtained, and bauxite is used to make aluminum. Guinea is the world's second largest producer of bauxite, after Australia, and it accounts for around 60 percent of the country's earnings from exports. Guinea's mountain regions yield other valuable minerals, including iron, gold, and diamonds.

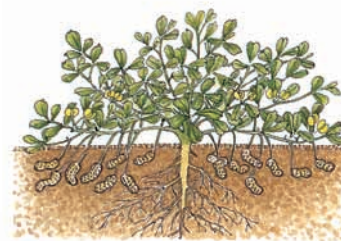
GUINEA BISSAU

SANDWICHED BETWEEN SENEGAL and Guinea, this low-lying, swampy country is a particularly unspoiled place. Once ruled by Portugal, Guinea Bissau was the first Portuguese colony to gain independence, in 1974. Today it is very poor and heavily dependent on financial aid from other countries. The people are a mix of ethnic groups, the largest of which is the Balante, from the south. Most people scrape out a living by growing coconuts, cotton, peanuts, or cashew nuts. Logging and fishing are also important.



ALONG THE COAST

Like its neighbors, Guinea Bissau has spectacular beaches. Its coastline is edged with mangrove swamps, mud flats, and estuaries leading to a maze of inland waterways. A huge variety of fish are found off the coast, and many people in this coastal region make their living from fishing.



PEANUTS

As the name suggests, the actual nuts of the peanut plant grow underground. The nut pods are pulled out of the ground and left to dry before being shelled and skinned. Some of the nuts are sold in local markets, but most are used to extract peanut oil, used in food production, or crushed to make peanut butter.



Cashew nuts

Find out more

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